



Fiona Stanley Fremantle Hospitals Group

Policy and Procedure

Sharp items: safe handling during therapeutic activities

Reference #: FSFH-MENH-POL-0024

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
Fiona Stanley Hospital Fremantle Hospital	Mental Health Service	Nursing, Allied Health

1. Introduction

The Mental Health Service has a duty of care to provide and maintain a safe environment for patients and staff. A variety of sharp items are used in therapeutic activities which may create risk. This document specifies the requirements and steps to be taken to promote a therapeutic environment for consumers and mitigate risks whilst engaging in activities.

2. Terminology

Sharp items

Any sharp, pointed or heavy item which has a high potential to be used for self-harm or as a weapon. Excludes medical devices.

3. Policy

- Sharp items must always be stored in a locked drawer/cupboard/office.
- A Sharp items list will be maintained and stored in the locked drawer /cupboard/office.
- Staff are responsible for ensuring sharps items are checked using the Sharp items list/visual prompt list, both upon access and return.

The Sharps items list must be checked and reconciled prior to commencement of the activity and at the end of access.

4. Procedure

4.1. Location and storage of sharps

Sharp items will only be located and stored as follows:

FH	FSH
Group Program Art Room	Youth Unit kitchen
Therapeutic kitchen	Mother and Baby Unit kitchen
Inpatient therapy areas	Staff hot desk area locked cupboard
W5.1 Treatment Room	Cockburn Health AHA Activity trolley drawer
Kara Maar: Therapy Kitchen and Group Room	

Sharp items are accessible to selected staff only:

Location	Staff with access
FH	Occupational Therapy and Nursing staff
Kara Maar	All staff
FSH Activity of Daily Living (ADL) kitchen	Occupational Therapists (OT)s and Nurse Unit Manager
FSH Mother Baby Unit (MBU)	All MBU staff
FSH-CH	Occupational Therapy and AHA staff

Keys for locked drawers/cupboards will be stored in the following locations:

Area	Key location
FH Group Program	Secure key box Group Program area – Passcode protected
FH Inpatient wards	OT office on each ward and Nurses Station W4.3
Kara Maar	Master key box/ staff carry on person

FSH ADL Kitchen	FSH Youth Senior OT drawer in hot desk area
MBU Kitchen	MBU Nursing station key cupboard
FSH Activity based groups – sharps storage	FSH Hot desk area
FSH-CH	AHA Office

- Other FH staff requiring access to sharp items are responsible for ensuring items are checked and returned.
- At FSH & FSH-CH drawers and cupboards can only be opened by OTs and Allied Health Assistants (AHA). Other FSH staff requiring access to sharp items must seek permission from Occupational Therapy staff who are responsible for ensuring items are checked and returned.

4.2. Patient assessment

- Review the patient's current Treatment Support and Discharge Plan, PSOLIS alerts and most recent risk assessment for the admission prior to accessing any sharp items:
 - Any changes to a patient's risk level or concerns which arise during the session will be documented in the medical record and feedback will be provided to the inpatient Senior OT and Shift Coordinator or outpatient Care Coordinator
- Patients using sharp items must be supervised. The level of supervision required will be determined by patient's risk assessment. AHAs will be directed by the OT allocated to the ward.

4.3. Requirements for use

- Document the use of sharp items as per the following site processes:
 - FH: Sharps Monitoring Book/Log (located with the sharps items).
 - FSH Sharps sign in sheet located in the kitchen sharps drawers and AHA locked drawers.
- The site-specific Sharps Monitoring book/Log must be signed and dated at each use.
- Staff must sign sharp items Out and In.
- Sharp items must not be left unattended with patients at any time.
- The sharps drawer/cupboard must remain locked, or sharps kept on the person of the staff member during the activity.

- The FSH Youth Unit ADL kitchen hatch must remain closed when there are no staff present and when sharps items are in use.
- All patients must remain in the area until all sharp items have been accounted for.
- Once sharp items are no longer in use, the items must be cleaned (if required) and returned to the locked drawer/cupboard/office.
- A physical check of all sharp items must be completed and recorded in the Sharps Monitoring Book/Log upon every access and return of the sharps item/s.
- If a sharp item is missing staff will immediately:

Report the missing sharp item.

- Notify any staff in the immediate vicinity and begin a search.
- Contact the last person to use the item.
- Notify the Nurse Unit Manager, Clinical Nurse Specialist, HOOT After Hours, Senior OT and Shift Coordinator on the inpatient wards if the item is not found immediately.
- Complete a Combined Hazard or Incident Report (CHoIR) and/or document as a clinical incident in the Datix Clinical Incident Management System as appropriate.

5. Compliance/performance monitoring

- FH OT staff / Kara Maar Team Leader and FSH senior staff are responsible for monitoring compliance with this document. Compliance will be achieved via routine monitoring of clinical incidents related to the use of sharp items.

6. Related policy documents

- SMHS:
 - [Injury Management](#) (SMHS 140)
 - [Work Health and Safety Policy](#) (SMHS:123)
- FSFHG:
 - Clinical Risk Assessment and Management (FSFH-HW-POL-0017)
 - Mental Health Assessment Unit Safe Ward Environment (FSH-MENH-POL-0011)

- Youth Unit Safe Ward Environment (FSH-MENH-POL-0010)
- Mother Baby Unit – Safe Ward Environment (FSH-MENH-POL-0020)

7. Related standards

- NSQHS standards
 - Clinical Governance
 - Comprehensive Care
- Chief Psychiatrists Standards for Clinical Care:
 - Care Planning

8. Authorisation

EXECUTIVE SPONSOR: Service Director Service 5					
Version	Date Issued	Compiled/Revised By	Committee/Consumer Group Consulted	Endorsed By	Revision due
1	02/2021	Safety, Quality and Risk Officer	Service 5, Safety, Quality and Risk Committee	FSFHG Policy Committee	02/2023
2	03/2023	Safety, Quality and Risk Officer		Service 5, Safety, Quality and Risk Committee	01/2025
3	Feb 2025	Safety, Quality and Risk Officer		Service 5, Safety, Quality and Risk Committee	12/2026